B1 Grammar

Must, have to and should

Talk about rules, obligations and advice, and know when something is not necessary.

English uses different modal verbs for rules, personal obligations and advice. The hardest part is the negative: *mustn't* and *don't have to* mean very different things.

Meaning	Form	Example
Strong obligation (often the speaker's rule)	must + verb	*I must call my mum tonight.*
Obligation from outside (rules, jobs)	have to + verb	*We have to wear a uniform at work.*
Prohibition: it is not allowed	mustn't + verb	*You mustn't smoke in the hospital.*
No obligation: it is not necessary	don't have to + verb	*You don't have to bring food. There's plenty.*
Advice	should / shouldn't + verb	*You should see a doctor. You shouldn't stay up so late.*
Past obligation	had to + verb	*I had to wait an hour for the bus.*

Only one past form. *Must* has no past tense, so use *had to*: *Yesterday I had to work late*, not *I must worked late*.

Common mistakes. *You must to go* is wrong: no *to* after *must* or *should*. And *You mustn't pay* means paying is forbidden; if paying is simply optional, say *You don't have to pay*.

Practice

1. Complete: Tomorrow is a holiday, so I ___ get up early. (no obligation)

2. Complete: You ___ use your phone during the exam. (not allowed)
3. Correct the mistake: She must to finish the report today.
4. Give advice: My friend has a bad headache.
5. Put into the past: I have to show my passport.

▼ **Show answers**

1. don't have to
2. mustn't
3. She must finish the report today.
4. For example: You should take a break and drink some water.
5. I had to show my passport.